

Insect Nets

Insect netting is one of the most important plant protection tools in organic and ecological agriculture. It considerably minimizes crop losses and the need for biopesticide spraying. In addition, it allows 90% of light to pass through and can be used in the middle of summer as it does not have a thermal effect on the soil and the crops.

Introduction to Insect Nets

- The type of net we recommend is the 25 g per m² model with a mesh size of 0.35 mm (0.0138 in). These nets adequately protect a wide variety of crops from the vast majority of insect pests.
- Always ensure that your nets are approximately 7 ft (2 m) longer than the length of your permanent beds. Keep in mind that the net must be long enough to be placed on hoops and must also be able to close properly at the ends.
- We use #9 (0.14 in or 3.5 mm) galvanized rustproof steel wire to build the hoops that are used to support the nets. The #10 can also be used. You can purchase them precut to the correct length or buy rolls of wire that you can cut yourself. Your hoops should be about 5 ft long so that they are approximately 2 ft high when installed.
- The hoops prevent crop foliage from coming into contact with the sides of the net. This contact is sometimes enough to allow some insects, such as flea beetles, to lay their eggs on the crop. Wire hoops may not be necessary if pest presence is low.
- Have plenty of sand (or rock) bags available. Calculate 1 bag per 5 ft (1.5 m). Keep in mind that 2 nets running parallel to one another can use the same bags on one of the sides.
- Handle nets carefully so that tearing is prevented for as long as possible.
- For storage, roll the insect nets on themselves then place them in an easily accessible location that is safe from rodents and weather.

Exposure to the elements causes them to age prematurely. Take care to group the nets according to their width (1 bed, 2 beds, etc.).

Strategies For Effective Use

Which Crops To Cover

A direct seeded brassica crop (like arugula, cucumbers, radish, mustard, baby kale) must be covered with an insect net at sowing time. The presence of a net will be even more effective if the bed is irrigated before its installation since the water repels certain pests such as flea beetles. The day of sowing, we install the net without the hoops. The following week, we open the net to cultivate with a flex tine weeder, then we add the hoops before putting the net back in place. This way of doing things saves a lot of time. Note that the net on these crops must remain in place until harvest.

Transplanted crops from the brassica family generally also need an insect net with wire hoops. We routinely cover broccoli, cauliflower and cabbages in their early stages or until the crop is so large that it takes up all the space under the hoops and net. Other brassica vegetables are covered as needed: kale (when small), rutabaga, winter radish and kohlrabi. Bok choy is always covered to prevent any damage to its foliage that would make it impossible to sell.

Transplanted zucchini, winter squash and melon are immediately covered with an insect net on wire hoops once they have been planted. In their early stages we protect them against the striped cucumber beetle and the squash bug. As soon as the flowers appear, we have to uncover these crops to make pollination possible. At this stage, the crop will be better at resisting pests.

Other crops are also susceptible to pests and can benefit from netting. These include Swiss chard, carrots, onions and leeks. Refer to the technical sheets of these crops for instructions.

How To Install a Net

This task can be done alone, but we suggest that two people do it together for greater efficiency.

Two-person Installation

- If you are using hoops, start by placing them every 5 ft (1.5 m), or about every 2 steps. If you need to install a net on several beds side-by-side, the hoops should be aligned on the horizontal axis. You then only need to add one bag per hoop.
- Install 2 hoops crosswise at each end of the bed for added strength.
- Unroll the net in one aisle.
- Then unroll widthwise on each side of the net, starting in the middle of the bed. Each person should be positioned on either side of the net widthwise. Go to one end by unrolling the net and hold it temporarily in place with a few bags. Do the same for the other half of the bed.



- Then put a bag over the net every 5 ft (1.5 m). Be sure to stretch it widthwise and lengthwise so that the sides of the netting are properly sealed.

Solo Installation

The method for installing a net on your own is essentially the same. The difference is that you will do one side at a time and then work your way down the other side until the entire perimeter of the net is unrolled. You then need to stretch it out properly lengthwise and widthwise.

Net Management

When crops are protected from frost by row covers in the spring, we wait until there is no longer a risk of frost before transitioning to the installation of nets.

During the summer, we remove the nets only when we need to perform an action such as weeding or harvesting. As soon as the work is finished, the net is put back.